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Roland Hanna

Pianist and composer Sir Roland Hanna was born in Detroit on February 10, 1932. His early training was in classical music and he studied at Eastman and Juilliard. By the late 1950s his passion for music realized itself in the world of jazz and he began displaying his versatility with a diverse group of band leaders. Roland has recorded frequently with the Thad Jones-Mel Lewis Orchestra, the New York Jazz Quartet and as a leader of his own trio.

Roland Hanna was the guest of honor at the Paradise Valley Jazz Party in Scottsdale, Arizona. He was interviewed there on April 15, 2000, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming in Scottsdale, Arizona at the Paradise Valley Jazz Party. My name is Monk Rowe and I am very, very pleased to have Sir Roland Hanna here as my guest.

RH: It's my pleasure, Monk. Thank you for inviting me.

MR: Congratulations on this honor you've got here.

RH: Oh that's really something. I never thought that I'd be the guy they'd be honoring. Because I always figured hey, I'm too young for that kind of stuff.

MR: Yeah, we were just talking about tributes. Be careful who you pay tribute to. You just were saying some very well thought out phrases about different piano players and I have to say it sounded to me like you were describing yourself.

RH: Oh no, no, no, not me yet. You know I'll tell you, I've worked hard at the piano. I've been working almost all my life trying to play the piano. And just when you think you're getting there, you're getting to a place where you can do whatever you want to do, something happens that usually you have no control over. And for the last ten, twelve years, I haven't been able to practice. I'm going to start back. But I haven't been able to practice. I've been working hard and teaching a lot, and there's no time for me to sit, as I used to. I used to, like for instance, if I were going to go and play a gig, say California or Japan, I used to sit and practice Chopin etudes and play Bach and just run through my Mozart or play a Beethoven sonata, maybe two or three times, and get my chops up, get my head up. And the reason I practice the classical music is because there are so many nuances and differences and changes to go through. Different minds coming together with music, and whenever I would play I had control over the piano, rather than the piano having control over me. But now I don't get a chance to practice. Boy it's like you've got five thousand pounds on your back. I mean I still want to do the same ideas, but they don't all come out. That's why I was talking about those guys — Monty Alexander and — what's his name — Petrucciani, and there's another one too, a young fellow who was a student of mine — oh boy names start to slip away — but he's a wonderful player. I

explained to him years ago, I can't even think of how long ago it was but it was more than twenty years ago, I said if you really want to get a control and command, play some Scriabin, play some Faure, play some Rachmaninoff, play some Chopin. Spend time practicing Chopin. They knew what the piano was about. And I told him just like that and he took me to heart. The next thing I know he had a beautiful album out, Faure, Chopin, Rachmaninoff. Yeah it was great, too, to hear that. He took the chords and form and shape of the pieces and he paid tribute to these guys. I thought it was wonderful.

MR: Isn't it curious that a lot of classical musicians are enamored sometimes of what a jazz player can do. At the same time a jazz musician looks at what they do.

RH: Well you know it always seemed to me that the guys who really are the giants are the composers who recognize how important it is to improvise. Rachmaninoff was a great improviser. Anton Rubenstein was a great improviser. Bussoni, Tosic, they were great improvisers. They could sit down and improvise on a Bach fugue. And anybody who plays the fugues, they know what I'm talking about. They know how difficult it is to do that. But they were also people who analyzed constantly. They were never people who just played notes. And that's the unfortunate thing that sometimes young students don't get the understanding that you have to know the form, the shape, the harmonies and you have to go beyond triad harmonies you see. Some classical people never go beyond triadic harmonies. When they do begin to understand that there's more than just passing tones and upper neighbors, well then they start to make really good music.

MR: So when you play Mozart or Beethoven, you're most likely recognizing the harmonies as they go by.

RH: Yes. All the variations and nuances that are put in. Like for instance in the Appassionata, the last movement, Beethoven is using the diminished chord over a pedal point you know. That flatted ninth that we call today in jazz, that, Beethoven may not have called it a flatted ninth, but he certainly heard it the same way we are hearing it now. And there are certain things that happen in Mozart. Mozart also was a guy who loved to make flatted ninths, but he would move them right away. See they were afraid of society, more afraid of society than we are today. They were afraid of overlords, people who would come and stop them from playing music if they did music a certain way. Look at Haydn, Franz Joseph Haydn, the "Farewell Symphony." There's an example of how afraid they were.

MR: Right. He couldn't come out and say what he wanted to.

RH: Yeah he couldn't come out and say look, you've got to take care of these guys, you can't just have us play all the time like that and don't take care of us. And one by one they just sneaked away. I mean I can imagine that happening. There's a funny story, and I hope it doesn't hurt anybody's feelings. But once I was working with Lionel Hampton. We had

taken a gig with him at Rodney Dangerfield's place in New York. I had a group called the New York Jazz Quartet at that time. And Hamp loved it. And I loved him, I always have loved him. But whenever we'd play together he would play, he'd never stop playing. He would never stop playing. So finally one day I said to Frank [Wess], I says, "Frank, I don't want to hurt his feelings, but how can we get him to know when the time is up? How can we get him to know that hey, we've played an hour and a half, and he wants to go on another hour and a half. We've got to take a break." Frank said, "Leave it to me, I'll take care of it." And so we're playing this tune and he's just wailing away. And Frank just sort of gave me a signal. Stop playing. And I stopped. And George was still playing, and Grady [Tate] was still wailing away. And Frank gave George a signal. And George stopped. And Grady was still playing, and Frank was playing too, behind him. And gradually Frank stopped. And Hamp is — and Grady stopped and we all walked off and left him. Of course the people thought that it was all part of the act.

MR: Right. That's funny. Did he get out of it gracefully?

RH: Oh yeah. He finally, no he understood. He laughed with us, you know, it was a big laugh. But I never wanted to hurt his feelings.

MR: Well I don't think he's changed.

RH: Even at this age, when he starts to play he still, he just loves to play. I think that's great. But you know you have to recognize that you have got other guys there too.

MR: Well you had certainly, your childhood must have had diverse musical influences. Your father was a preacher.

RH: He played saxophone and he was a preacher as well.

MR: And was there church influence in the musical end of things for you?

RH: I think so. I never went into the church and played piano in a church. That never happened. But my father loved to play saxophone. And so that certainly had to have some effect on me. Although he died when I was seven years old. But my sister played, my mother played, I had a brother who played the trumpet and violin, and I had another brother who played the saxophone and one who sang, actually two who sang. The oldest one sang but singing was never a major thing with him. He became a doctor. And the one next to me loved to sing. He used to like Lawrence Melchior — I don't know if you know that name, Lawrence Melchior was a great tenor. And he used to come on every Sunday and Lagraus would sing with him. But my situation was a little bit different. The piano was for my sister and my mother, not for me. And I used to bang on it, I was about three years old and used to bang on it. And I kept banging on it. And I kept banging on it. And finally they took it and put it out in the barn.

MR: Oh gee. I thought you were going to say finally they got me some lessons.

RH: No, no, no. They said you want to bang on it? Bang on it out in the barn. And I did, winter and spring and summer and fall I'd go out there. I got so good I used to cut the fingers off my gloves in the wintertime, and put my coat around my neck and go out and play, and practice that piano. I'd get some hours in some days, until I got old enough and started — it seemed like I was going to be serious about it — I was about ten or eleven years old. And then she says okay, you can get a piano. But I had to go through a lot to get a piano. When I was about eleven or twelve, I met Tommy Flanagan in high school. And Tommy was really the first guy to open my eyes to jazz. I had heard jazz, but I didn't care too much for it up until about eleven years old. And when I heard Tommy play I went right up to him and I said what kind of music are you playing? You don't have any music in front of you. What are you doing? He said, "Don't you know about Charlie Parker?" I said, "Bud Powell? Who is Bud Powell?" Finally, because I would sit, after he'd play, I'd sit right down and play a Chopin etude. And he'd say you got all this from this music? So we just exchanged ideas, and it was Tommy who influenced me, really, to play jazz. He said, "Hey, do you know the changes to the blues?" We were at the Northern High School, a long time ago, I hate to think how long ago it was. But no, the church, although it had an influence, it didn't have a direct influence. It wasn't until I was a grown man that I began to use elements of Gospel music actually.

MR: Did you have aspirations to become a professional classical pianist?

RH: Yes. And at some point I did. When I was sixteen years old I made a promise to myself to become a concert pianist. I didn't know that I was going to go to the Korean War. I didn't know I was going to get in the Army. That kind of changed things. And then when I came out of the Army I went to Juilliard. And the time I spent in Juilliard let me know that it wasn't the music of Chopin and Brahms and Beethoven that I had to play, it was the music of my people. I had to play Duke Ellington and Fats Waller and Fletcher Henderson. These are my people. Just as Rubenstein was playing the music of his people, Chopin. Just as Horowitz plays the music of his people, Scriabin and Rachmaninoff. I had to play the music of my people you see. And I think it's not so much that you are forced to do that but it's incumbent upon you. You are born into a certain situation. And you have to learn to accept that and to do something with that. Because world culture can only become a blend if people accept it and understand it. When people try to deny their particular culture, well then what they do is they eliminate something. They eliminate something of humanity. But when people recognize the individual culture of their people, where they come from, then they contribute to world humanity. That's so much more important to me than nationalism or just this thing belongs here. No, we're on a planet. We're on a place where everybody is involved. That's the thing that's so beautiful about it is that there's so many differences and we all have to contribute to it. And so that was

like an awakening to me. I like to call it an epiphany because when I was young, nobody ever talked to me about that kind of stuff. And then I became aware of all of these great people. I mean Willie "The Lion" Smith was a great pianist, Lucky Roberts was a great pianist, Scott Joplin was a great composer, Jelly Roll Morton was a great composer. These people, they meant something. And all of that now, a hundred years later, is meaning something to everybody in the United States. Young people who don't get that information, it may take them until they're 65 or 70 years old to understand where they come from. But I was lucky to get that before I was 30 years old and to know that this is the direction I have to go in, and not so much playing Chopin etudes, even though I use all of that all the time.

MR: Right. Was it a gradual realization for you?

RH: I think it was a kind of — I can't say it was gradual because after I came out of the Army it seemed to me that that's what I had to do. And when I went to Juilliard I concentrated on developing piano skills for that reason, not necessarily to play concert. Although at the age of sixteen I said that's what I want to do, I want to be a concert pianist. But coming out of Juilliard I said well if I am going to be a concert pianist, it's going to be in a different way. It's certainly going to be playing "Daydreams," or "Lush Life" or something like that.

MR: Yeah, in concert.

RH: Yeah that would be it. You know one of my mentors was Art Tatum. And he was truly a concert pianist. Whenever he played, no matter what he played, it was like a concert piece. And Horowitz — the violinist, I can't think — anyway three famous concert musicians went into hear him play one night and they came away saying if this man had wanted to be a classical pianist he probably would have been the greatest classical pianist who ever lived. Because he would make up all that music on the spot. And still, this is like 45, almost 50 years after his death, there still hasn't been anybody else to do that. So he was sort of a mentor to me. I said to myself I want to be able to do something like that. And I've been, at the Aaron Copland School of Music I've been training people to do just that. I have a young fellow by the name of Jeb Patton who is going to be in that same vein. A wonderful player. He plays with the Heath Brothers, you've probably seen him and haven't noticed, but he's in that same vein.

MR: Were you sent overseas for the Korean War?

RH: I went to Alaska and I went to Hawaii. I played "Rhapsody in Blue" in Hawaii. And up in Alaska we didn't do very much of anything. But I was in Ft. Lewis, Seattle, mostly, playing for generals and captains, and that kind of stuff. No, I didn't go to Korea but I played off a lot of guys. When I was in the war I used to play cello. And I would go, instead of playing cymbals, which is what they had me doing in the band, I would take

my cello out and we'd go to the boat and I'd have to be there so I'd take my cello and I'd play to guys. They'd look down and say, "Who's playing the cello down there?" I played Pepper off — who else did I play off? I played a number of guys off. I was part of the band so we had to do it.

MR: Well after this change of career perhaps, you proceeded in a short number of years to play with a really wide variety of people, from Benny Goodman to Charles Mingus in the space of about a year?

RH: As a matter of fact at the same time, during the same time. Benny Goodman came about as a result of, I think Teddy Wilson or somebody said no. He was supposed to do the Brussels Worlds Fair or do a tour in Europe. And somebody that he would normally call canceled and said no. And so he had the idea to call Juilliard and see if he could get some young person. And it just so happened that I was there at the time, and one of the teachers, the dance instructor, was a friend of Benny's. She was a friend of Muriel Zuckerman. And I used to play dance classes, because I was always improvising. And she recommended me. So I went up to Benny Goodman's house, and it's a funny little story goes with this. He lived on 66th Street, just past Second Avenue. And I got to his apartment and I was just so nervous. The guy at the door says, "Can I help you?" I was so nervous I says, "Yes, I'd like to see Mr. Tommy Dorsey please." And the guys said, "You mean Benny Goodman, don't you?" I was just so nervous. But I never told Benny that.

MR: That's a good thing I think.

RH: But anyway I went up and played for him. He asked me to play a couple of tunes and I played "Love for Sale," and something else, something, I think "Yesterdays." And he says okay, "You'll be okay." And then we had rehearsals. I met Arvell Shaw and Roy Burns and we went up to Stamford, Connecticut and rehearsed up there. And then I did the tour, I think I had to get permission from the school to take off and do the tour because although I wasn't graduating, it would have some reflection on my grades. So I told Benny, I said, "Benny I'm not sure they're going to let me do this." So he called the school. "No problem, Mr. Goodman." And he called from Europe after we were there, they extended the tour and he called from Europe and said, "He won't be back for his exams, can you give him his exams in June?" Now school ended in May. And they said, "Mr. Goodman, no problem." So he could do whatever he wanted to do. It didn't matter. When I got back they gave me the exams, no problem. And soon after that, this was in 1958. Soon after that I had met Mingus before in 1957 up at some sort of camp, we were playing a summer festival and Mingus came up and sat in. And after I got back from Brussels, Mingus called me and asked me if I'd come and work some gigs with him. So it was the same year — '58, '59 — and I was still off and on with Benny until he hired me

on a regular basis. And then around 1960, February or March, Sarah Vaughan called. Her bass player, Richard Davis, had recommended me to her and I went out with her. And that was fantastic. That was the greatest experience I ever had musically up to that time. I learned more with Sarah Vaughan than I did in all the five years at Juilliard. But she has amassed so much information in her singing and by playing for her and hearing chords and the way she could, she passed that right on to me, just taught me the kind of art of listening to harmonies. She could sing in one note exactly what harmony I was supposed to play. She was a scary lady. I'll give you an example of how scary she was. We were at Birdland opposite Count Basie's band. She got worked up one night and she just sat next to each horn player in the reed section and sang their parts to one of the pieces. Each one. She just moved from one to the other and sang their part. That's how great she was. I don't know anybody who could do that. But she just sang, while they're playing, she was singing right next to them. And I was following and listening, just amazed. That lady was a genius. She was born a genius. We played once a recording session for Billy May and she sang "The Green Hills of Summer" and they went over it 19 times. Each time she sang it she sang it impeccably differently. Now I was in the session. That's what I mean. That's how great she was. And each one, I think that's probably why they never put the record out, because whoever had to listen to it couldn't decide which take was the best take. She sang it 19 times not because anything was bad but they wanted to see if they could get more. She was amazing, really.

MR: Each one of these people, Goodman to Mingus, and I guess Sarah, had a reputation as being a taskmaster.

RH: They were.

MR: Was it a positive experience for most of it for you?

RH: I think so. You know to answer that question I have to go back and remember my relationship with Benny. Benny was a great clarinetist. He could play any music, classical or jazz. But he had some restrictions on himself. He wouldn't allow his jazz to be as free as it could have been. He was limited to the chord changes that had been played. He was not open to fresh chord changes. If you tried to do anything a little different, he'd say oh no, no, no, no. And he used to ask me to come up to the house just to play and play and play, so that he could try to open that door. But whenever we'd get to a song like "Again," a simple song, and I'd throw in a few little — he said, "What's that chord you just played, what's that?" He'd ask me. And I'd say, "Well it's just an F seventh going to a B flat minor." He'd say, "Well don't play that, isn't that supposed to be C minor?" He couldn't adjust to things like that. And Mingus on the other hand was a taskmaster in terms of getting guys to play a certain way for him. You know now he didn't have that kind of schooling where he could tell what was supposed to be played.

That's why he kept practicing the piano, he was still trying to get his harmony chops. He used to call me late at night and ask me how to play a certain bridge or whatever. But the saxophone players that he had, he used to give them a hard time. He used to tell them, "No you've got to play the New Orleans type jazz," you've got to do this, you've got to do that.

MR: Was there a lot of singing of parts to you?

RH: Yes.

MR: And you had to like get them that way?

RH: Yes. Mingus would sing out parts. He'd sing out the things he'd want. It wasn't until later that he started to work with Sy Johnson. He was working with Jimmy Knepper first. And Jimmy Knepper used to help him to write out his parts. Then later when he got older and he couldn't really write anymore, he started to get that disease, he got Sy Johnson to help him. But when Knepper was working with him he'd sing thing to Knepper and Knepper would write them down and then they'd put it together. And he used to do that to me if he wanted a certain chord. He'd sing a certain thing, and try to play the bass note, and then I would give him the chord and tell him what it was. Because he didn't know. As great as he was, sometimes he didn't know the chord. Mingus had played with Art Tatum and played with Duke Ellington, had played with a great many pianists. But the actual harmony he didn't always know. And we'd sit down and talk a lot about academic harmony. What he did know was how to play the bass. He was a phenomenal bass player. You can't take anything away from Mingus in terms of that bass. But he didn't have much stamina for steady, steady, steady tempo. And I think that's one of the reasons why he did something new in jazz, giving jazz this shift of rhythm and shift of time, starting out with one kind of time and then, without a conductor, changing it suddenly. And it was a good thing that he had Danny Richmond with him for so long because Danny was with him like they were like on water skis going together, shift the time just like that. But with Sarah there was a different situation. She loved to rehearse. She didn't like to sing at the rehearsals but she loved to rehearse. Wherever we played, when we got there we usually rehearsed three or four hours. And there would be some new tunes, and she would give me ideas as to how to set up the arrangement. The scary time that I had with Sarah was when we played Harrah's in Reno, Nevada. This was like the first gig where we had a band. And she didn't tell me that I'm supposed to write out the arrangements for the band. So when we get there, suddenly the guys said, "Where are the arrangements, where are the parts?" I had to sit up like the whole weekend and write arrangements. This was the kind of taskmaster she was. She said, "Look it's your gig, you're my musical director, it's your gig, get my charts."

MR: Did you get a chance to hear them before the gig?

RH: Well at least I got a chance — Bobby Bryant, the trumpet player, a wonderful trumpet player, he was on the gig and he helped me a great deal. I managed to write about six charts and he wrote about three or four more. And when I got hung up writing them — you probably know Gerry Wiggins.

MR: Yes.

RH: The pianist, a wonderful pianist. He let me have his apartment to do the writing. And then he came and helped me by doing some copying for me. Because those guys, I'll never forget them because they were great at a time when I knew nothing.

MR: What size band was that?

RH: That was — let's see — four saxes, one trombone player, two trumpets. It was a small band, a twelve piece band probably. The rhythm section was me, Richard Davis and Percy Brice. And nine other guys. We had no guitar. But it had to be a nice band.

MR: The time with Sarah was early 1960s?

RH: Early 1960, 1962, 1962. I left sometime in 1963.

MR: Did you ever have any hassles in different parts of the country traveling with that particular group?

RH: No. Not with Sarah. With Al Hibbler. But right after Sarah, right after I left Sarah, and that was not a very good way to leave anybody— Sarah had a husband at that time, his name was C.B. Atkins. And he left us stranded. Didn't pay us the last week in the hotel in Las Vegas, and didn't get an airplane ticket for us to get out of there. So they just left. Well of course we stayed and we called the union back in New York and Hy Jaffe was the treasurer at that time. And he called Sarah's house and he told C.B. if he didn't get a ticket out to Las Vegas immediately, this was like just the same weekend, if he didn't get a ticket out to Las Vegas, Sarah would never work in the United States again. We got a call from Western Union that same night, said our plane tickets, the money and everything is here at the Western Union, your tickets are here. So Hy Jaffe was serious. He was power. And he probably could have stopped her from working just like that, because they didn't take any stuff from anybody. That's why the union was powerful at that time. This was like 1963. Now, people do anything they want to do. Anything. There is no power. But see times have changed so much and nobody's even noticed it. It wasn't that they were overlords or anything like that, it was that they looked out for the musicians. By the same token, the musicians had to take care of themselves. Sarah was part of the union. She was a pianist you know. You probably know that she got her start working with Earl Hines and Billy Eckstine playing piano in a Earl Hines' band. So they wouldn't stand for her husband or manager mistreating the musicians. So we had tickets that night. But anyway, to answer your question, I worked with Carmen McRae right after that and went back to some of the same places that I played with Sarah. That was a

good experience. But then when that ran dry I went to work with Al Hibbler. And Al Hibbler and I were in Miami, Florida, playing in a hotel/bar type place that had a restaurant. This was in 1965. And as a matter of fact this was the same year I met Monty Alexander. Monty came in that same night and played with us. I told him I said, "Look, this is my number, you come up to New York I'll get you some work. You play too good to be down here, man, come up to New York." He was 18 years old I think and he came up. Anyway after we got through with the gig Al wanted to get something to eat. Well we were in the bar and the restaurant was right next door. You'd go out of the bar and you'd go right into the restaurant. And we were staying in the same motel. We get into the restaurant, I'd lead Al in through the door, and instead of walking all the way in we sat right there by the door. The stools were kind of high for me. They weren't too high for Al. So I kind of ambled my way up there and we're sitting there for a while and nobody shows up. Finally I said, "Waitress, waitress." And she came over and she says, "We don't serve the colored." Just like that. It caught me off guard completely because we'd been playing all night long. And no sooner that she said we don't serve the colored here comes two great big cops in the door, they walked right in. They says, "You having trouble here, Annie?" And Al says, "Let's go." You know we got up and went right back into the bar where we were. It was a kind of a close call because I was a hothead in those days, I was a young nut. I mean like I said, these two great big guys were as tall as the lamps. They could have swiped me out with one blow. But I had kind of a hot temper in those days, you know how we are.

MR: Well those were active days too, in civil rights.

RH: Yeah there was a lot going on in those days, and Hibbler took part in some of that walking. I never did, I didn't take any part in any of that except to give lip service. But I think those people did a fantastic job to lay their lives on the line to get people to recognize that hey, the Civil War is over a hundred years. Forget about that stuff. I don't know if they'll ever forget it.

MR: In 1970 — well tell me about your knighthood.

RH: Oh that was a great experience for me. In 1969 I had been with the Thad Jones band for about two and a half, not quite three years, because Hank [Jones] started with him even though Thad and I talked about my being part of the band before he hired Hank, when he finally did it he hired Hank. But Hank was busy with television and couldn't do it all the time so every time he couldn't do it he'd call me and say, "Roland, would you take over for me?" Of course I took over. And finally sometime in '66 I had a lot of students, I told Hank I'm busy, I've got students, and if you can't do this gig let me know so I can arrange to do it every Monday. So Hank said okay, you've got it. And I started working with the band. And this association with the band, it sort of branched out. A lot of people

began to hear me play and one night in my studio on 73rd Street in Manhattan, somebody called and asked me if I would consider coming to Liberia to play concerts. And of course I said yes immediately. There was no money involved. They had no money to pay. But they needed some people to play. And it turned out that they were asking people from various countries to contribute their part in the concert situation so they could raise money to build schools in Monrovia. And Jimmy Randolph or James Cheatham, I don't know if you know that name but he was an actor in "Guys and Dolls" on Broadway, he's a singer. And we went together. We met several people from Turkey, people from Germany, people from France, acrobats from Italy who did live wire. So it was not a circus but they put on a show and we were part of the show. We would perform songs from Randolph's "Guys and Dolls" and then we'd sing pop tunes or whatever, and we went there for one week and the thing was so successful they kept us for another week. So we stayed in Liberia and moved from Liberia to Senegal to Cote d'Ivoire, we went to Guinea Bissau, we went to several countries close by. Liberia is only about 85 miles deep, about the size of New Jersey. And we went to several countries around and did performances. And they apparently raised quite a bit of money. Every other night they would have a big party at the Secretary of State's house, Grimes was his name. His wife would put on a big spread, food I had never seen or tasted before. And so when the second week was over we were invited to the President's house in Monrovia. He had a huge castle. And he had those 24-foot ceilings, you know, marble all over the flooring. It was just gorgeous. And he had myself and Jimmy Cheatham to come there and he asked us, he said, since we can't give you money would you accept knighthood? And of course I said yes. So that's how that happened. And when I came back home we got a telegram for me to come down to Washington, D.C. to the consulate, the Liberian consulate, and bring my family. And I went down and kneeled and they dubbed me knight commander you know, that's what it is, and that experience, that gave me a great, big, huge emblem that was around my neck and somehow that disappeared. I didn't lose it, I think somebody just took it. It had a big emblem on it and colors, the colors of the Liberian flag. And I don't know where that is now. But the plaque, I have that. My wife hangs that on the wall. But I'm very proud of that because it means so much more than money. The money would have been spent that week. But this has lasted for thirty years, thirty one years. So that's how that happened.

MR: Did the citizens of those countries respond to what you played?

RH: Yes. The people would come, and most of the time they were young people, they were between the ages of eight and seventeen or sixteen. They would respond, yes. And sometimes they'd come up and try to talk to us and ask us how did we learn or how long have you been playing or questions like that. Oh yes they responded. Jimmy Randolph, I

don't know where he is now, but he was quite an open singer, an open person. And he had a tremendous personality. Being an actor, they would gravitate to him. And the overflow would come and ask me a few questions, because I am the accompanist in that case. But I think he handled everything very well. They really liked it. He was sort of like a Paul Robeson type person, just big voice, great big smile, happy man. He was a tall guy, he was about six feet two, three, something like that. So he had a persona involved. And it seemed to me that my experience in Africa gave me something that I hadn't had before and that was a look at people who, although they were poor financially, they were rich in spirit and in the fact that they have a home. And it's the kind of spirit that when I got to America I didn't see that. It wasn't there. That happiness, that glow, that feeling of belonging. I didn't see that in America. You are a young man, in those days people would sometimes be loaded down with drugs in the corners of Harlem, you'd sometimes see people who were just literally wiped out and had defeated attitude. I suppose you could see the same thing now except that most of those young men have been put in jail for one reason or another. You know one-fourth of the black population is sitting up in jail houses you know. So the changes that have come have not all been good and they haven't all been bad, it's just a balance. I don't say that I would trade living in America for living in Africa, and then again maybe I would, who knows. It might be a wonderful thing to live in Africa for a time.

MR: Well it's such a huge continent too. I'm sure it changes from one country to the next.

RH: Yes it does, it does. And it's like having fifty or sixty or seventy-five different countries in one place, although you know you're in Africa, and you know that you can go from Dahomey to Ivory Coast to Guinea to some other place, thinking that it's like going from one state to the other. It's not. It's a totally different thing.

MR: Have these kinds of experiences found their way into inspiration for compositions for you?

RH: Oh yes, of course. I wrote a ballet more than ten years ago now, that was commissioned by a company in Columbus, Ohio, and the ballet is called "My Name Is Jasmine But They Call Me Jazz." And it was played about five or six times. The ballet had to stay in their control for five years, and we have it now. We haven't been able to produce it because it's a big thing to produce a ballet but we have it back now. But I have recorded some of the songs. At that time, when I did it I couldn't record any of the songs because they belonged to them. And I've also written for the Library of Congress a sonata called "Quest Sonata" that uses elements of African-American music, not necessarily jazz, but elements of African American music. But you would have to know that, because the interpretation of the player makes a difference. If I play it you'd definitely hear jazz. But if someone else reads it and they play it they would play it like a classic player.

MR: There you go. Trying to get something on the page.

RH: Yeah. It's very hard to do, which is why jazz itself, we were able to continue keeping it because people got it from the record, not from the written page. Although you have jazz bands and they play jazz and they read music, it's because of the band leader being able to instill the jazz inflection to that music. But if you don't have the right people you're not going to get that music. It takes a long time.

MR: Let me just play something here, to see if you—
[audio interlude]

RH: That's "Perugia"

MR: Nice chords. What was the inspiration for this particular song. Was there one?

RH: Perugia is a place almost in the center of Italy, and it's a city on the top of a hill, high on the top of a hill, where the Etruscans, a group of people who escaped from slavery or enslavement in Africa and ran to this area, and stayed there and fought back the Romans and other people by throwing hot oil and rocks and everything else down. Finally the Romans said let them go. Forget them. And they won out. If you read that history, it's really interesting. And when I got there, knowing nothing about that, I watched these people every day at the top of this hill, and the top of the mountain, with these columns of these buildings and looking like Roman columns, and I said how did they get up there? These people built all this stuff by hand and they walked from one end of the street to the other. And there's a certain time of day when all the shops close and people just walk promenade. And the introduction that you hear is the promenade [scats] and they're just trudging and walking back and forth. And here I am in amazement looking at this most amazing thing to see. And then, as I stayed there, I think it was about a week or two, with Thad Jones and Mel Lewis band, and as I stayed there I used to go for long walks and try to walk down the hill on the streets. And you'd walk down a ways and the next thing you know you're back up on another hill. You'd walk a while then you'd go down this road and it would curve around and you'd be back. There was one way to get down. And you had to go that way to get down off the hill. But any other time you wanted to get down, and you might go down for a ways, but you'd have to end up back on top of the hill. So Perugia was just so beautiful to me. I'd never seen anything like that. And that's where that melody came from. But it wasn't an inspiration from Africa, it was more an inspiration from these very, very brown, light skinned but brown skinned people, with the combination of dark eyes and dark features and black hair. Not Sicilians but close. And I've never gotten over Perugia. I think if you go there now you might see what I'm talking about because that tradition still goes on, they still walk back and forth in the certain time of the day, everything still closes up and they still walk back and forth like nomads.

MR: Thad Jones-Mel Lewis band was a nice career thing for you to do it seems like, and you had some great moments on that record too.

RH: When Thad left the Basie band in 1962 we were neighbors living in the same town. I had known Thad since the 40s from Detroit, Pontiac days you know. Thad lived in Pontiac, I lived in Detroit. And when he left the Basie band he got a gig at Columbia at CBS. His brother Hank was the pianist for Arthur Godfrey and so Hank got Thad a job with the house band there. And it crushed Thad. He had to have a job, but that wasn't the kind of job — he was hoping it would be something playing jazz. And occasionally Monk would call him, occasionally he'd play with Coleman Hawkins or he'd play with this person around the town, but he wasn't happy. And so I had a gig at the Five Spot. And I hired Thad. I used to have Coleman come and play with me too. I was friendly with all of them and I would invite them down: Kenny Burrell, anybody. So Thad came and played with me on a regular basis. He came several times. And one night we were playing and some Japanese people came in and they were looking for a group to go to Japan to make a movie. And they came and heard the group and they loved the group and they went around and they heard everybody else and they came back and said look, "We'd like you to come to Japan to make this movie." So I asked Thad if he would go. And while we were there, now this is in 1963 I think it was, while we were there I talked Thad into getting his own band. And I said look, all you need is a good bass player, good drummer, good piano player. Now I was the leader of that group, but I said I'll be your piano player if you want to make this band. And I don't know whether Thad believed me or what. I think he believed me because when he got back he began to write and write more and more. And finally sometime in 1965 he had been working off and on with Mel Lewis and I think the idea that I gave him, he passed it on to Mel Lewis and then they decided to get the band. And I felt kind of left out when he hired Hank, because I had asked him about that first. But it turned out okay, because probably he talked to Hank more than likely, I don't know for sure. But he probably talked to Hank and said Hank, I hope you can make it but if you can't man, tell Roland to come on and play. That's probably why Hank told me to come. So it was a good move. And it was a good move only because Thad wasn't like Mingus or Sarah or Benny Goodman or anybody else. Thad was open to trying new things. And often times he would let me start out playing, and wouldn't stop me until half the set was over. So I played the whole set and my chops developed. Richard and Mel behind me, we'd do all kinds of things. Avant garde. In those days they called it avant garde if you'd go out. And we used to go out and come back later. And we did stuff like "Fingers" and "Once Around" and a lot of things that were just really — Every Monday night at the end of the last set, Thad would point to me and say okay you got it. And I would make up, improvise on a tune. Basically it was the same tune for a while, and I'd

just make it up. And then one night Thad came in with an arrangement on this tune. I said, "Thad, isn't that my tune?" He said no it was mine. He wrote it out.

MR: You should have written it down.

RH: Well see that's one of those things that there's no way you can ever re-do that.

MR: Well Ellington did the same thing I hear.

RH: Oh yeah.

MR: You know he'd hear the guys playing the riffs, and okay.

RH: But I never faulted him for that because he was just doing what band leaders did you know. If you throw an idea out there, he'd take it and write it down.

MR: Well you've done a lot of teaching over the years and you still do. Do you teach jazz per se or do you teach a lot of different courses?

RH: I teach two ensemble courses, and that is undergraduate ensemble courses. There are all kinds of elective classes that the kids can take. But the ensemble classes are classes that give them a chance to learn about jazz. Most of them don't know anything about jazz. But whatever they can do when they're undergraduate people, they're allowed to take this elective class. And when they come in I don't know what instruments they're going to play, it could be clarinet, alto, tenor, it could be a French horn, it could be a violin player, it could be an oboe player, flute player, anybody. And if we have a bass player and a drummer and a piano player what I do is I take the basic tunes that we all play and I teach those tunes. And I correct the wrong notes that are there and I try to give them the proper inflection or phrasing, and then I try to explain to them how to play on the harmonies. Some of them come away grasping the idea. I have to demonstrate an awful lot. I have to sit down at the piano and actually play. You just can't write out notes and say, "Do this." It has to be hands on. And sometimes I'll take a saxophone player and the rhythm section and play with them. Ask the other piano player to stand up and look, and pay attention to what I'm doing. And when they come back they get a better sense of how to comp or how to voice a chord. They listen to it and then after the class I'm usually inundated with questions, because it takes the whole class for them to think of the kind of questions they want to ask. So I have to make myself available for them. And the testing isn't just telling them to do something, it's doing it and having them watch or listen or play along or try. I have to go from ten to ten sometimes just to be with the students. You know, ten o'clock in the morning to ten o'clock at night. Because if I close my doors well then I lose the students. So I keep the doors open so anyone that has questions they want to ask, they come in and ask. Then I have a graduate class that's with students who already know how to play jazz, and I make them write. See the idea is the more they write the more they search, the more they search the better they get. It's like if you work at something you really want you can't help but increase your information. You can't help it. And it's the

same way they taught me at Juilliard. I had some excellent teachers. Gordon Stanley would give me pieces that I thought I'd never be able to play. And I'd get to like say after three weeks of playing and still wasn't there, and he'd ask me to come out to his house. He lived in Bryn Mawr, Pennsylvania and I'd come out to his house. And he had private students. And I'd be up in the attic, in that hot attic, practicing on that dummy keyboard. Then when I'd come down and play for him he would correct all the things I was doing and he'd say, "Now slow it down. If you can play it slowly, you can play it fast." See those things I never got from other teachers. He was my best teacher. He gave me information that nobody else would give, now I'm just giving it back. And it works. Because I've been there, this is almost the tenth year. And I have some people, Jesus you wouldn't believe, when you hear this young kid Jeb Patton, you'll know what I mean. He's amazing. He plays everything. He plays from Bach to bop.

MR: And I see your son has a thing out now, he's a singer?

RH: I'm very proud of him because you know when he was young I wanted him to play the piano, and he said dad, that's not for me. He told me point blank that he was going to be an engineer. But he never stopped singing. So now, he came back to me and he says, "I want to sing." I says okay. Come to find out he's a good singer. He had developed on his own. Sometimes your kids have to go away and get their own thing.

MR: I'll try to remember that.

RH: You know, some people, they don't let their kids go. But when he told me he wasn't going to be a piano player I said hey, I'm not going to force you. And he had to live his own life, I can't live his life for him. But his singing, he's not operatic, and he doesn't sound like Billy Eckstine, he has his own sound, and he's just naturally musical I guess, from being around me and my musical situation. But he's naturally musical. And when you hear the record you'll know what I mean. And what I did was I took several of my students, one by one, and I infused them into the recording session so that I would have professionals and my son and the students as well.

MR: That's a great experience for them.

RH: Yes it was. And one of the guitarists, he's a wonderful guitarist, named Stan Young, a young fellow, he really is a young fellow, he's 25, 26, something like that. And he was just, when he heard the record he couldn't believe how good it sounded. But I'm still doing that and I'm planning to do more. We have one coming out on Jeb Patton. We plan to do another one, we've got one, I have a young saxophonist by the name of Keytayake Aomori. Now he's the son of the young bass player that I have on this record now. We're putting out another one on him. And I plan to do some things that won't include me, just the students, or just the new people. But on these first four it's been me with everybody else, and me with Michael. "Michael Hanna at Home With Friends."

MR: Well it's been great conversation.

RH: Well thank you.

MR: I have to say listening to one particular solo you played today, that you really have what I consider to be a composer's sense in your improvising. There's a great use of a mixture of chording, rhythmic things, and you did something just in octaves, you know, one octave delayed off the other, and I mean it's a great device.

RH: I try to use material that sort of either — I can't say needs development — but develops itself. I try to let the music develop itself. That's what I try to do. When I make a conscious effort at it it doesn't work. But when I make a feeling effort, in other words when I let the music flow out, then it works. And whatever I have to do to get it out, it's not so much that I'm forcing the physical part, the physical part happens. Like sometimes I can hear repeated notes. Fortunately for me I had teachers who taught me how to play repeated notes. Because otherwise I'd be trying to do it with my wrist and you can't do that. But they showed me how you do it with your fingers. You just do it. So now I'm practicing enough so that it's natural. And those things come out, not because they're technical but because it's part of the way I hear now. I was talking to Brunious a while ago about Alvin Batiste. And Alvin Batiste is one of those people who hears a certain way. And having studied his clarinet so much, he does things very naturally. I don't know whether you know him, if you do know him you might know what I mean. When he plays he plays an angular kind of pattern that shift back and forth before you know it, and he's playing on regular harmonies, but it's very unusual sounding. Well that's what happens sometimes when I play. It develops, but I never know how it's going to develop. Never know. It just happens on its own. Well thanks for thinking of that.

MR: Well somebody called it, jazz was the music of surprise, so I guess — mostly good surprises.

RH: Well anyway—

MR: Well keep it up. We talked a long time.

RH: Well it was a pleasure.

MR: Yeah, thanks.

RH: I enjoyed it. Thank you very much.